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AI • DIGITAL TRANSFORMATION

Agentic AI Is the Next Frontier in Autonomous Marketing

Marketers can apply the reasoning and decision-making capabilities of AI-powered agents to perform increasingly complex tasks

Imagine a marketer being able to rapidly scale and orchestrate customer journeys from start to finish through a fleet of AI-powered marketing assistants. Within seconds, a team of AI "agents" creates multiple customer profiles, identifies journey steps, selects meaningful touchpoints, and develops assets to engage customers. After a quick human review, the AI agents execute actions, sending out emails or personalized messages, for example. When a new insight emerges about customer behavior, the agents adapt with customized content or messaging.

With the next wave in AI development on the horizon, this vision—an example of so-called agentic AI—is becoming a reality. While many organizations are still experimenting with generative AI, some early adopters have already begun building more intelligent AI-powered agents, which have greater cognitive capabilities than the current generation of AI bots.

In contrast to current iterations of AI, agents can perform complex tasks with greater autonomy by analyzing structured or unstructured data to take initiative, make

decisions, and act on them. Companies can combine multiple agents to execute complicated assignments that typically would require coordination among numerous functions. Agents can even “learn” from one another to optimize their performance with limited human involvement. Together, these skills allow agents to tackle nonlinear, iterative processes—a capability that can give them great potential in marketing, where brands must continually adapt to changing customer and business needs. Agents are also well suited for the marketing function because they can create high volumes of tailored content and coordinate sophisticated processes involving many handoffs around the world.

While generative AI use cases to date have primarily been useful for saving time and money, agentic AI could be a value-add because the tool can adapt its thinking to continually improve. Initially, AI agents will likely be most helpful in simplifying operational and analytical tasks, such as content tagging, creative review, versioning, localization, and campaign reporting. Building on existing generative AI capabilities, agents can enable autonomous workflows with decisioning logic that moves the process from one generative AI-enabled task to another. With less human intervention, these capabilities can be scaled in unprecedented ways.

As the underlying technology matures and agents develop more nuanced decision-making skills, use in customer-facing tasks will likely expand, including journey orchestration and personalization based on a customer’s demonstrated or anticipated behavior. With AI agents handling operations like brand compliance review and campaign optimization, human marketers can turn their attention to more strategic work—and better address the ongoing mandate to do more with less.

Preparing for Agentic AI

As CMOs plan for the year ahead, they can consider how best to prepare for and capitalize on the possibilities enabled by agentic AI. While the technology is still developing, CMOs can take the following steps to lay the groundwork for adoption:

1. Identify early use cases. Marketing leaders can consider setting up an internal task force to develop a strategy for implementing agentic AI. This group should bring together functional leaders, including in the IT organization, to identify tasks that can be handled by AI agents, break marketing processes down into specific steps, and select pilot use cases. CMOs can learn from early applications of AI agents in the service domain, where some companies are using agents to support call centers and to facilitate more personalized interactions.

As they experiment with different use cases, organizations can better understand how AI agents can deliver the most value to their organizations. Because agents can learn and adapt, organizations could leverage the collective intelligence of multiple agents to continually refine their work. For example, AI agents could one day help marketers explore new markets and modes of engagement. With the goal of identifying and developing opportunities for growth, agents could tailor content and channels within a campaign, then adapt their approach based on knowledge gained of specific customer micro-segments.

2. Ready the martech stack. Without an accessible data infrastructure, AI agents can't properly learn from and act on customer data. To ensure their martech stacks are ready, CMOs can modernize their approach to data governance, access, and architecture. If they haven't already, CMOs can invest in tools such as customer data platforms and digital asset management systems, which can help centralize business and customer information.

3. Rethink roles and responsibilities. At first, AI agents will take on more discrete tasks and require more regular human input. Marketers might define initial business and marketing processes that are time-intensive yet rote, map decisions to be made and desired outputs, and thoroughly review AI-generated output. Teams will have to learn through trial and error which tasks agents are best suited to handle and how to engineer effective prompts to kickstart agent productivity.

Eventually, marketers may be able to manage multiple agents, each with its own area of specialization. AI agents will be able to act as autonomous systems, breaking tasks into subtasks and developing their own optimized workflows. CMOs should assess their team to identify employees who can oversee a fleet of agents by prioritizing workflow, assessing risks, maximizing productivity, and identifying creative opportunities for growth.

4. Anticipate potential risks. Because AI agents can act autonomously and make decisions much faster than humans, a misstep can have a ripple effect, particularly when several agents are making decisions in a sequence. To avoid an unwanted chain reaction, organizations can insert time delays into the AI ruleset or add additional human checkpoints. Human intervention also may be necessary to ensure agents aren't exposing sensitive customer data or confidential company information. While they may eventually take a more hands-off approach to certain tasks, humans should always play a role—ensuring that both employees and customers trust the process. Leaders can proactively educate and engage their teams around the potential disruption, with a focus on how the new technology will add value.

Most marketing organizations are still just beginning to implement generative AI. Yet the next evolution of AI technology is already on the horizon, and it has the potential to be much more disruptive. For marketers—who often face resource constraints and the expectation to do more with less—agentic AI could be a powerful tool in the quest to identify and tap into new areas of growth.

—by Christine Cutten, principal; Jenny Kelly, managing director; and Lauren Teegarden, senior manager, all with Deloitte Digital, Deloitte Consulting LLP

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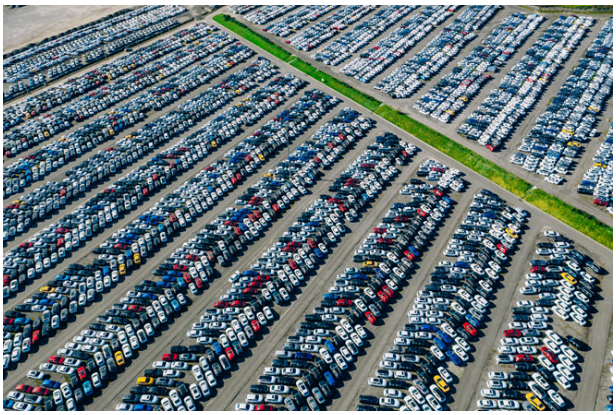

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